

Techfest 2026-27

ZeroCode

Overview

Anyone can type a message into an AI model. Very few people can write the one message that gets it to build exactly what they had in mind, on the first real try. That gap, between prompting casually and prompting with precision, is quickly becoming one of the most valuable skills of the AI era.

ZeroCode is a national prompt engineering challenge from Techfest, IIT Bombay, Asia's largest science and technology festival, built to test exactly that skill. This is not a hackathon about who can write the most code, and it is not a contest about who owns the most expensive AI subscription. It is a test of prompt architecture: the ability to plan, structure, and iterate an idea into a fully working, interactive web application, on a shared platform, under a shared clock.

Every participant works with the same free AI model and the same time limit. What separates the finalists from the field is not the tool in their hands; it's how precisely they use it.

Challenge Question

Build a working, interactive one-page website using only AI prompts, no manual coding allowed.

The type of task is known in advance: you'll be building a single-page interactive web page. But what exactly you have to build, and the specific features it must include, will only be revealed when the round starts.

Your first 5 prompts are free. Every prompt after that costs you points, and using too many can get you disqualified. So plan first, then prompt with precision.

If your page takes an input and gives an output, it will also be tested with real values to make sure it actually works correctly, not just looks like it does.

Eligibility & Participation Rules

- **Individual competition:** ZeroCode is an individual challenge. Every participant builds and submits their own entry independently.
- **Who can participate:** Open to all students with a valid ID from their educational institution.
- **Own device:** Participants must bring their own laptop. Devices are not provided at the venue, so make sure your laptop is charged, updated, and able to run a browser smoothly before the round starts.
- **Pre-event access check:** Every participant must have a working Google account, logged in and tested on Google AI Studio and CodePen, before the day of the event. Login or access issues discovered mid-round will not pause the clock.

Competition Structure:

Round 1: City Zonals

All participants gather at their registered regional city zonal for a live, on-the-spot build round. This is where the actual competition happens: here's exactly how it works, step by step.

- **The reveal:** At the start of the round, participants are told the exact theme for their city and the exact list of mandatory features their web page must include. Neither is known beforehand.
- **The build window:** Participants get **70 minutes** to build their solution.
- **The mandatory pipeline:** Every participant must use Google AI Studio, on the Gemini Flash model, to generate their submission as three separate files: `index.html`, `style.css`, and `script.js`. Only vanilla HTML, CSS, and JavaScript are permitted, no frameworks or libraries of any kind (React, Vue, Angular, jQuery, Bootstrap, Tailwind, etc.), whether loaded via CDN or otherwise. Submissions found using any framework or external library will be disqualified. Participants can preview their work by opening `index.html` directly in their browser at any point during the round.
- **The prompt limit:** Your first **5 prompts are free**, no penalty. Every prompt **beyond that reduces your final score**, as detailed in the Evaluation

Criteria section below. If your total prompt count exceeds **15**, your entry is **disqualified**. Every message sent to the AI model counts as one prompt: the first master prompt, any follow-up asking for a change or a fix, a regeneration of an unsatisfactory response, a short "continue" if output got cut off, and any clarifying question, all count. The only thing that does not count as a prompt is re-testing already-generated code inside CodePen without sending anything new to the AI.

- Switching chats: You're free to start a new chat in Google AI Studio at any point during the round, there's no penalty for doing so. Only the prompts sent in your final submitted chat are counted and scored, starting fresh means rebuilding your context from scratch, switching costs you time. Just make sure your final submission, including your final chat link, is made within the 70-minute build window.
- **The submission window:** Once the **70-minute** build window ends, a Google Form link will be shared and kept open for exactly **7 minutes**. Within this window, every participant must upload their three files (`index.html`, `style.css`, `script.js`), their Google AI Studio chat link, the full list of prompts they used (in order), and a final confirmation of submission.
- File naming: Files must be saved and submitted in the format `<CompetitionID>_index.html`, `<CompetitionID>_style.css`, and `<CompetitionID>_script.js`.

Round 1 is scored entirely against the fixed evaluation criteria and feature checklist announced on the day.

Round 2: Finals at Techfest, IIT Bombay

The top-performing participants across all city zonals are shortlisted and invited to Techfest, IIT Bombay for the final round.

- New theme: After all zonals conclude, finalists will be handed a new theme and a new feature checklist.
- Build & present: Finalists will build their solution following the same core rules, same mandatory platform, same prompt-architecture approach, with any adjusted parameters (such as time limit or prompt cap for the final round) communicated to finalists in advance of the event.

Timeline:

Event	Deadline
Registration closes	As per the date of the respective city zonal
Round 1 Submission	On the date of that city zonal
Zonal Results	On the date of that city zonal
Round 2: Finals at Techfest, IIT Bombay	16th - 18th December 2026

Evaluation, Prizes, and Recognition

Evaluation Criteria

Every submission is scored against a fixed, published rubric: the same rubric, applied the same way, in every city. The exact features a judge checks for under "Core Feature Completion" are announced on zonal day as a Pass/Fail checklist.

Criterion	What it measures	points
Core Feature Completion	Are the mandatory features (announced on zonal day) present and working, checked Pass/Fail against a fixed checklist? Where the task takes an input and produces an output, this also includes testing the submission against a fixed set of input values and checking that the output matches the correct expected result.	50
Interactivity	Does the app respond correctly and in real time to user input (sliders, buttons, forms, etc.), load without noticeable delay, and remain fully responsive and usable across	15

	different screen sizes (desktop and mobile)?	
Visual Clarity	Is the layout clean, readable, and usable on a standard screen?	15
Error-Free Execution	Does the web page load and run without breaking or throwing visible/console errors, checked by opening the submitted <code>index.html</code> file directly in a browser and interacting with every required feature?	10
Creativity	Any thoughtful, working touches beyond the minimum ask that genuinely improve the tool, without breaking any required feature.	10

Prompt Efficiency Deduction

The first 5 prompts used by a participant carry no penalty. Every prompt beyond this baseline reduces the final score, with the penalty increasing more steeply the more prompts are used.

Deduction = $(N - 5)(N - 4) \div 2$, applied only when $N > 5$, capped at a maximum deduction of 15 points

Total prompts used (N)	Deduction
1-5	0
6	-1
7	-3
8	-6
9	-10

10	-15
11 or more	-15(capped)

Final Score = Base Score – Prompt Efficiency Deduction (floored at 0).

Tiebreaker: If two participants receive the same final score, the entry that uses fewer total prompts is ranked higher.

General Rules

1. Participants must register online at techfest.org and will receive a Participant ID for future reference.
2. Registration remains open until the date of the respective city zonal.
3. The organizers' and judges' decisions are final and binding. Techfest reserves the right to verify participant details at any stage.
4. Only **Google AI Studio (Gemini Flash model)** may be used to generate the submission. Only **vanilla HTML, CSS, and JavaScript** are permitted, **no frameworks**, libraries, or external dependencies of any kind. Use of CodePen or any other rendering tool is **not required and not permitted** as a substitute for the submitted files. Any submission found using a framework or external library will be disqualified.
5. Your first **5 prompts carry no penalty**. Every prompt used beyond 5 reduces the final score as per the published formula (maximum deduction: 15 points). If your total prompt count exceeds 15, your entry is disqualified. Submission of the three files ([index.html](#), [style.css](#), [script.js](#)), their Google AI Studio chat link, the full list of prompts they used (in order) within the **7- minute window** is mandatory for evaluation.
6. Manual editing of the generated code is not allowed; all changes must be made through prompts.
7. Techfest, IIT Bombay is not responsible for late or lost submissions, or for issues arising from a participant's own device, browser, or internet connection.
8. All work submitted must be the participant's own, produced live during the round. Prior preparation of a theme-specific solution, or outside assistance during the round, is not permitted.
9. **No external reference material**, other AI tools, browser extensions, or outside assistance of any kind may be used during the round; only the

sanctioned Google AI Studio.

10. The latest information will be available on techfest.org, and registered participants will be notified of any changes via email.
11. All technical, procedural, and competition-related queries must be submitted directly through the Techfest Competition Portal under the Doubt section. Participants are strictly requested to regularly check the portal for answers and updates
12. Official communication for important announcements will be through the email siddhi@techfest.org. Queries submitted via email will not be entertained.

Certificate Policy

1. The **top 15** participants per zonal city advancing to Round 2 receive a **Certificate of Excellence**.
2. Participants scoring above a critical mark (to be determined) receive an **E-Certificate of Participation**.

Prize Money

Prize money will be awarded to the **top five** teams via NEFT, latest by May 2027.

Prize Money Submission Process

- **Submission Channel:** Complete the prize money form **directly on the website** after the final round concludes. The winners would be able to view the form through their registered email ID
- **Deadline:** The form must be submitted by **December 31, 2026**.

Details Needed for the Website Form

When filling out the form on the website, make sure you have the following bank account details ready:

1. Account Holder's Name
2. Account Number

3. Bank Name and Branch Name
4. IFSC Code